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Slenderness and strength in balance

Secondary elements boost primary function

Every architect knows the famous axiom from Louis Sullivan. Form follows function. And every architect also knows the challenge of bringing that saying into practice. The desire to create a sleek and interesting design must be met with an equal consideration for practicality. It is in striking that perfect balance that you make a winning design.

Belgian architect Philippe Samyn, of Samyn and Partners, found this balance when creating a new fire station in the city of Charleroi. The fire station houses 48 fire trucks which enter and exit at high (and lifesaving) speeds. So the doors are a crucial component of the design. In fact, Samyn identifies the doors as the "the key item of concept" of the final building.

"There are many suppliers who can give you good doors. The difference is in the refinement of the door. Technically and aesthetically. I like refined details and it has to fit with the characteristics of the site," Samyn says. By finding a door that fit both his vision and the functional requirements, Samyn was able to craft the building around it as a whole. Defending the specifications of the door was easy because it was the best door for the job, and just happened to add a quality of style. According to Samyn, "our client and the contractor put some more money on this very important item to make sure that the global system would be good."

The doors allowed Samyn to master the aesthetic of his building down to the finest details.
The appearance and functionality of Charleroi would have been drastically different if a door that was not as slim, weather-resistant or fast moving had been installed. Aesthetically it would have failed to live up to expectations and reduced functionality would lose precious seconds in the race to save lives. Specifying details, such as doors, and integrating them from the onset supports a more holistic and realized design from ideation to implementation.

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How BIM has changed design workflow for the better

From pioneering CAD to the world's largest BIM object: architects and engineers talk

Building design is complex. Regulations are ever-changing. And managing a process with a fluid group of specialist designers, engineers and suppliers inevitably creates challenges in terms of communi-cation, time and cost. Since its creation, BIM – or Building Information Modeling – has evolved into an invaluable tool for architects and engineers, bringing immense advantages for the entire planning and process stage.

The New Karolinska Solna Hospital in Sweden was designed in one of the world's biggest BIM models. White Arkitekter had over 120 architects and engineers working on the project at the same time. According to project engineer Jörgen Pell, BIM enabled "... more people to be in the same file and carry out different tasks at the same time." And this turned out to be crucial to ensure White Arkitekter hit their deadlines.

BIM has freed architects from the restraints of working in isolation with a set of Rotring pens and CAD. Architect and computer-aided design pioneer Philippe Samyn says that BIM has given his firm "a better means of communi-cation." Not only can they go much deeper into each project, they can make the experience "very pleasant for the client".

This view is supported by Christopher Schmidt of Rainer Müller Architekten, Hannover, who says, "We can show the customer his or her individually designed gate in 3D. This represents the future – and a great competitive advantage for us."

If BIM is part of your workflow, you and your team will find that the ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems BIM object library is a simple way to specify all of the entry systems you'll need for your project.
As Schmidt says, "The ASSA ABLOY Entrance System BIM library has convinced the employees of RMA Architects". You can explore our BIM object library at bimobject.com

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Sustainability showcase or showdown?

With an increasing need to consider future generations, creating sustainable buildings, designed for tomorrow as much as for today, needs to be a priority for the whole industry. When designing a building we must consider all the elements that need to come together to meet the needs of both the occupants and the environment.

The New Karolinska Solna Hospital (NKS) in Sweden has been designed to meet strict high environmental targets – the gold Miljöbyggnad standard in Sweden, which translates into a platinum LEED certification. This could be seen as a tall order for a hospital. Jörgen Pell, engineer at White Arkitekter, told us that the difficulty lies in how much energy a hospital requires, and how functionality has to be optimum. This means that the validation lies largely in what materials, and how much of them, are used in the hospital, and how energy efficient the building is.

Equipment and lighting need a constant supply of energy. By ensuring the lighting systems are all LED and having high specification standards for where lights should be Pell and his team have made lighting very efficient. Thinking about how to retain the heat and energy within the building has been another primary target. Making sure facades are well insulated, and choosing to install double entry entrance systems - with either two sets of sliding doors, or a revolving door and a sliding door - has limited energy and heat loss through the walls and entrances of the buildings. And in the event of a citywide loss of power, the hospital has a self-sufficient energy supply in the form of an underground energy system designed to keep the hospital 'online'.

Using the right manufacturers has also helped the NKS achieve this goal. One of the primary ways the hospital has met its energy requirements is by using the right materials – materials that are healthy for people and the environment. Using suppliers such as ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems Pell and his team were able to monitor every material that went into the building and keep the environmental standards high.

Designing and building such a large hospital, and managing to achieve such high certification is a huge success for White Arkitekter, and the architecture profession as a whole. As Pell says, "We have taken responsibility for showing people that it's achievable to build in this way." And hopefully they have set the bar for the future.

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Specs, how low can you go?

Throughout every building project, planning, designing and building, getting the specifications right is crucial. When architects specify a product it is for a particular reason, maybe the product has a particular function it needs to fulfil, or the design is complex and needs specific products and materials to realise its full potential. Whatever the reasoning, specifications are not there to be ignored.

At the New Karolinska Solna Hospital (NKS), specifications had to be high. In any hospital functionality is the primary consideration, however another major challenge of the hospital was to ensure that the environmental goals were met. Jörgen Pell, in charge of NKS' doors, worked with ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems to ensure the doors met the required specs.

Functionality comes first and the hospital needed doors that would welcome patients, family members, and staff, while also ensuring high levels of security and control. Choosing ASSA ABLOY sliding doors, and fitting them in pairs enabled more efficient use of space and complied with the required security standards.

The environmental specifications for materials used throughout the building were thorough. Pell and his team had to work closely with manufacturers to make sure all materials were compliant with the specs. ASSA ABLOY were able to meet the doors healthy material requirements, and with low U -values and the double door system installed, able to further reduce NKS' energy losses. By meeting these specifications the NKS has achieved gold Miljö-byggnad status and platinum LEED certification.

Quality and suitability make specifications matter. The specified product has the durability to last, the right U-values, the desired functionality, it fulfils the brief. It should never be the case that the contractor, or a manufacturer, ignores the specs in pursuit of a financial saving. That is why, when it comes to defending specifications ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems have designated consultants to help you fight for your design.

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Are you in compliance?

Permissions, regulations, standards, building control, you have to make sure your building is compliant with them all. But it's not all red tape, compliance can be seen as an opportunity to create more efficient buildings, to improve health and safety, and to save costs. And with the right manufacturers you can be sure that the entrance systems you choose go above and beyond when it comes to compliance.

White Arkitekter have led the development of the New Karolinska Solna Hospital (NKS) in Sweden. The hospital had to be in compliance with standard building regulations, as well as rigorous medical standards, while also being flexible enough to meet the standards of the future.

Working with ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems, White Arkitekter were able to ensure that all entrance systems installed were compliant with hospital regulations. Front entrances have to fill certain criteria to satisfy safety and security regulations, and with the Besam sliding door White Arkitekter were able to ensure that their doors were compliant with fire, safety and security regulations. Internally all the doors exceeded the standard safety requirements due to the fitting of motion sensors.

A further standard for the NKS was the longevity of all the products used. Entrance systems have to continue to work safely and efficiently and keep up with regulation standards. ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems were able to offer peace of mind to the hospital, and its architects.



Compliance is part of the everyday reality of every project you work on and ensuring compliance is as painstaking as it is crucial. But when you can draw on the guidance of specified suppliers whose products adhere to all relevant regulations, and who are prepared to work with you to make sure your specifications meet all requirements, it doesn't need to be a big deal.

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Regulating indoor climate for staff productivity – and customer satisfaction

The right entrance systems can encourage a happier and more productive workforce, especially if the weather gets extreme.

Studies show that keeping workers and visitors comfortable throughout the day encourages a healthier work-life balance and significantly increases productivity. Comfort depends on regulating airflow, noise and fluctuations in temperature. And in this, architects have a key role to play, even in something as simple as specifying the right doors for each unique site.

The most obvious way to reduce heat loss and control exposure to the great outdoors is to choose an entrance system with insulated glass and a good seal. So, when Alpine chalet Cesa da Fuoch in the Italian Alps needed a door between the indoor restaurant and the terrace that gave unrestricted access to customers with ski gear, their architect turned to ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems.

After a brief consultation with ASSA ABLOY the designer opted for a Besam Slim Thermo with high insulation, U-factor glass, double glazing, and TightSeal. The door's high performance keeps the warmth in and the cold out, ensuring staff stay comfortable. And with happy staff comes higher customer satisfaction.

Entrance systems that help regulate indoor climate are key to productivity inside. That's why ASSA ABLOY Entrance Systems offers a complete range of door solutions with sensors, optimal speed and multiple-glazing to give you greater control over your building's internal climate.

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